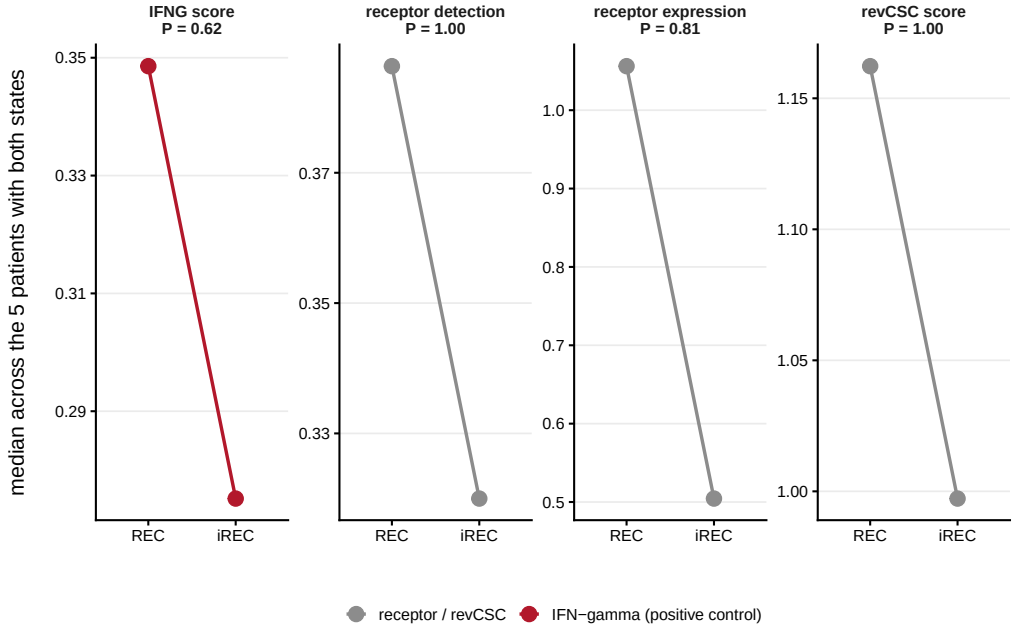
a

The REC vs iREC comparison is underpowered, not negative

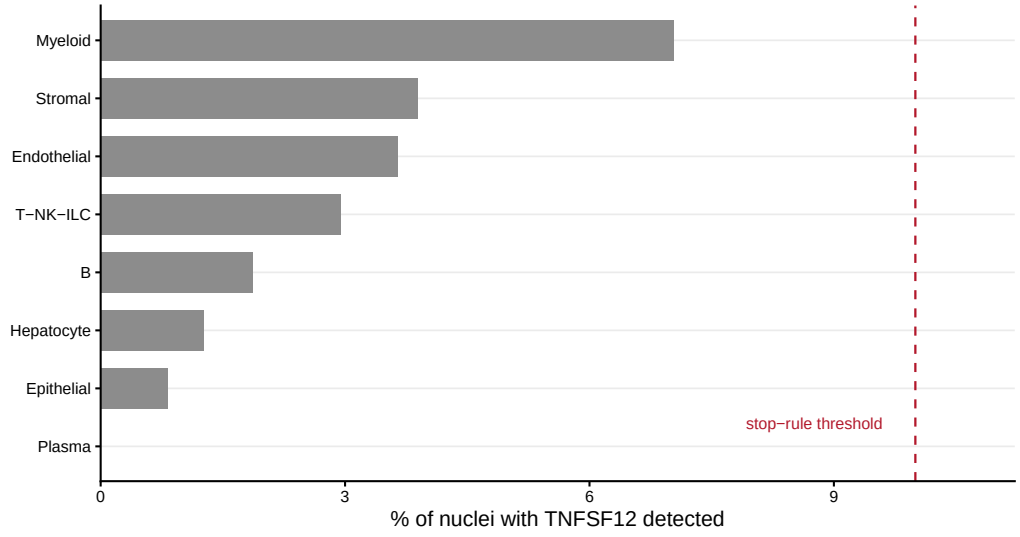
only 5 patients carry >=20 cells of both states. The IFN difference that DEFINES the two states is itself not recovered (P = 0.62, wrong direction), so the receptor result here carries no evidential weight either way.



b

The ligand is too sparse, and has no consistent source

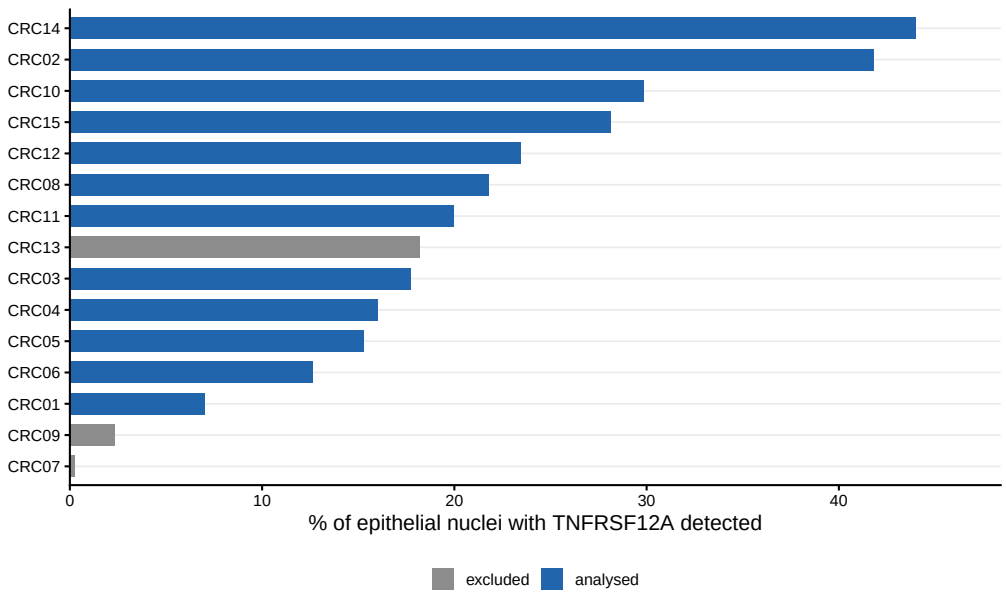
no cell type reaches 10% detection (max 7.0%, myeloid). Across the 12 patients with >=10 positive nuclei the top source is epithelial in 6, myeloid in 5, T/NK in 1 −> stop rule met.



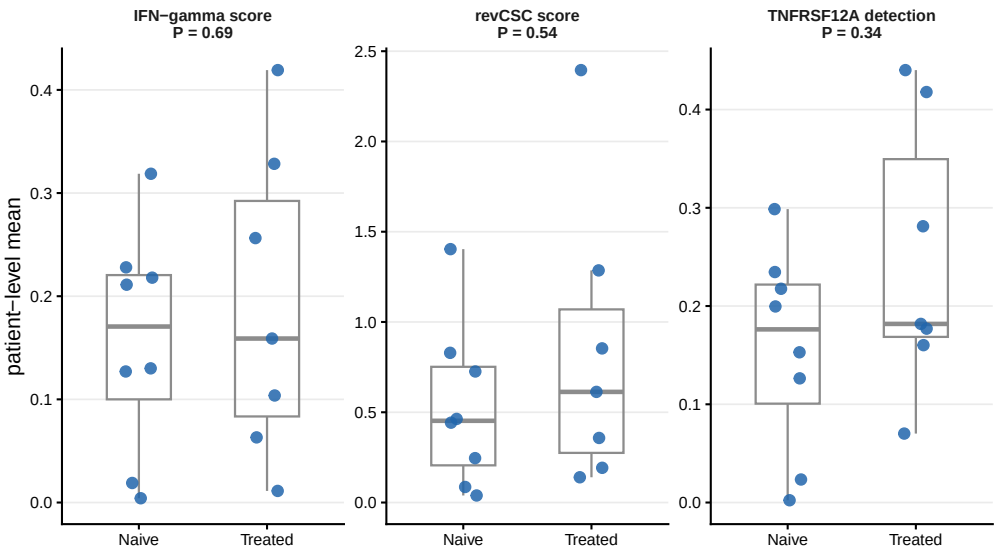
c

Receptor detection varies widely between patients

3 of 15 patients excluded before testing (CRC07 0.2%, CRC09 2.3%, CRC13 n=22), on pre−set thresholds, not on their results.



d

Prior chemotherapy does not shift the receptor or either axis

every patient shown; 7 treated vs 8 naive, all P > 0.33. These are not paired pre/post samples, so this is exploratory and cannot speak to treatment−induced plasticity.